



TWELVE-MONTH PROGRESS REPORT

West Africa: progress report, 2025-08-01 to 2026-08-05

Edition of 2026-08-10 · 43 systems and instruments tracked, 2 of them not held

Compiled 2026-08-10 from the Data Landscapers source base. Sections run from the region's institutions outwards to what funds them. Each opens with a movement ledger comparing the position at the start and end of the period, which runs to the date of issue rather than to the last month's close.

Of 43 bodies, instruments and systems on this place's ledger, 31 changed position between 2025-08-01 and 2026-08-05, 3 did not, 4 carry no stated baseline, and 2 are Not held at both ends. A further 3 took a position dated after 2026-08-05 and are carried in the status report rather than compared here.

Shape check, run before the comparison: 180 sources for this place in the window — 46 in the earlier half (2025-08 to 2026-01), 134 in the later (2026-02 to 2026-08). The two halves are comparable, so the comparison is made over the whole window.

Movement values. *Advanced* — a system entered service, a stage was completed or an instrument was made. *Stalled* — a stated target passed without delivery. *Regressed* — an instrument was withdrawn or neutralised, or a measured position worsened. *Closed* — the programme ended. *No change* — the position at both ends is the same. *Baseline not held* — the base carries no position at the start of the period, so no movement can be stated. A value may carry a qualifying clause after a comma, as in *Advanced, slipped*.

Summary of the period

On 2026-07-19 at Lungi the ECOWAS Authority [adopted a Revised Supplementary Act on the Protection of Personal Data](#), superseding the Act of February 2010, welcomed Council instruments on open data, electronic communications, digital governance and roaming, and approved a Regional Cybersecurity Coordination Mechanism. None of those texts is published with the communiqué.

PI-SPI, the union's instant-payment rail, [reached 30 million connected users](#) by 2026-07-20 on 80 connected institutions against 45 at launch, and the BCEAO [extended the connection deadline](#) it had set for 30 June 2026. The confederal credentials of the three states that left the bloc are meanwhile being issued, on specifications [unpublished since 2024-11-22](#).

Institutions and mandates

Cybersecurity

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
ECOWAS Regional Cybersecurity Coordination Mechanism	Did not exist	Establishment approved; no terms of reference, seat, budget or staffing held	Advanced

Regional collaboration

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
Alliance of Sahel States (AES)	A common biometric passport launched in January 2025; harmonised document specifications validated but unpublished; no confederal card issued	Both confederal credentials issuing, a cross-border enrolment run on another member's soil, and a national data centre offered as mutualised AES infrastructure	Advanced
BCEAO (Banque Centrale des Etats de l'Afrique de l'Ouest)	Operating the SICA and STAR systems, with the instant-payment platform in test phase	Operating the union's instant-payment rail, participating in the ECOWAS payment project and preparing a pilot accession to the continental one	Advanced

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
ECOWAS	Vision 2050 in force; the Supplementary Act of February 2010 the newest regional digital instrument the base held	Adopted a revised data-protection Act, welcomed Council instruments on open data, electronic communications , digital governance and roaming, and approved a regional cybersecurity body, in one paragraph	Advanced
ECOWAS project-preparation pipeline for digital connectivity	Did not exist	Digital connectivity placed alongside transport, energy and water in the pipeline for development finance and private investment; no project list, envelope or first report held	Advanced
WATRA (West Africa Telecommunications Regulators Assembly)	Working groups established about two years earlier, with no technical output on record	Five technical reports finalised, a 23rd general assembly held at Lome, and a regional position stated on submarine-cable resilience	Advanced

The Regional Cybersecurity Coordination Mechanism the Authority [approved on 2026-07-19](#) is a body rather than a declaration, and the base holds nothing else on it: no terms of reference, seat, budget or staffing.

WATRA closed a two-year working-group cycle at Ouagadougou on 2026-04-12, [finalising five technical reports](#) on 5G deployment, submarine-cable resilience, cybersecurity frameworks, consumer protection and non-geostationary satellite regulation, which executive secretary Aliyu Yusuf Aboki called a shift from dialogue to the delivery of regulatory tools. None of the five is held here.

The Alliance of Sahel States, which severed its ECOWAS ties in 2024, is building a parallel layer. Niger's prime minister [enrolled for the AES passport on 2026-07-16](#); Burkina Faso [enrolled its residents in Mali](#) in June 2026, a first on another member's soil; and Mali's data centre was [offered in the short term as mutualised AES infrastructure](#).

Instruments and harmonisation

Digital Payments and Fintech

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
BCEAO connection obligation for instant-payment participants	Interoperability announced as mandatory from 30 June 2026	Banks, e-money issuers and payment institutions have until 30 September 2026 and microfinance institutions until 30 June 2027	Advanced, sl

Strategies, plans and policies

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
ECOWAS Regional Digital Single Market roadmap	Did not exist	Adopted as a commitment to harmonise policy across interoperable fintech, unified digital ID and rural broadband; no work programme, timetable or budget held	Advanced

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
WATRA technical reports on 5G, submarine-cable resilience, cybersecurity, consumer protection and NGSO	None published	Seven documents published: the cybersecurity working group's final report, the infrastructure working group's 2023-2025 report covering 5G, NGSO, cable resilience and WRC-27, the 5G deployment and policy framework, the submarine-cable resilience recommendation s, the consumer access and experience regulatory synthesis and two of its seven constituent guidelines	Advanced
ECOWAS Digital Sector Development Strategy 2024-2029	Adopted October 2024, text unpublished	Still unpublished, so its targets, budget and implementation arrangements are unestablished; the roaming implementation progress report and the directive on cyber confidence-building measures adopted alongside it are unpublished too	No change

Standards

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
ECOWAS free-roaming regulation C/REG.21/12/17	In force since December 2017, implemented between Liberia, The Gambia and Sierra Leone (2025-02), with full implementation by all mobile operators due by end-2025	A second three-state arrangement live, giving free incoming calls for up to 30 days and local rates on outgoing traffic; the end-2025 deadline passed with six of fifteen member states covered	Advanced, a
AES harmonised specifications for travel and identity documents	Validated and referred to the heads of state; no approval, gazetted text or reference number	Unchanged, while both credentials built on them are issued; no published text located	No change

Data protection

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
ECOWAS Supplementary Act on the Protection of Personal Data	The Supplementary Act of February 2010, the regional benchmark national bills were still being drafted against	A revised Act adopted; its text is not published with the communique, so what changed against 2010 is not establishable from the base	Advanced

AI

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
ECOWAS Regional AI Governance Framework	Did not exist	Resolved to be developed, citing algorithmic bias, labour displacement and information disorder; no draft, drafting body or date held in the six months since	Advanced, m
Francophone West African AI governance guidelines	Did not exist	Adopted by Benin, Burkina Faso, Cote d'Ivoire, Guinea, Mali and Senegal; advisory, complementing national strategies rather than replacing them	Advanced

National statistics

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
ECOWAS regional statistical methodological guides	The Regional Statistical Programme 2023-2027 under implementation, with no adopted methodological guide held	Guides on the industrial production index, the business register and public debt statistics approved; those on government financial transactions and quarterly national accounts returned for finalisation	Advanced

The Revised Supplementary Act on the Protection of Personal Data [was adopted on 2026-07-19](#) on the Council of Ministers' recommendation, replacing the Act of February 2010 against which national bills across the region have been drafted. The communiqué neither reproduces nor summarises it and the base holds neither instrument, so the supersession can be recorded and its content cannot.

Two AI instruments sit at different stages. ECOWAS [resolved in January 2026](#) to develop a regional framework, and no draft is held six months on. Outside the bloc's machinery, six states — three of them AES members — [adopted shared AI governance guidelines on 2026-07-06](#), convened by the advocacy organisation Niyel and advisory rather than binding.

Harmonisation moved furthest where an instrument had operational consequences. The directors-general of the national statistical institutes [approved methodological guides](#) for the industrial production index, the business register and public debt statistics at Dakar on 2026-07-31. Under the roaming regulation of December 2017, Senegal, Togo and Benin [brought a free-roaming arrangement into effect at Lomé on 2026-04-24](#): free incoming calls for up to 30 consecutive days, local rates on outgoing traffic.

The BCEAO's connection obligation slipped. Interoperability [was to be mandatory from 30 June 2026](#); the central bank then [set 30 September 2026 for banks, e-money issuers and payment institutions and 30 June 2027 for microfinance institutions](#).

Shared systems and infrastructure

Connectivity

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
CSquared West Africa backbone	Carrying regional traffic on its own subsea and terrestrial routes	Capacity on the 2Africa West system added for route diversity, after three multi-country outages in 28 months at the Accra, Lagos and Abidjan landing concentration	Advanced
EllaLink Mauritania branch	Launched at Nouadhibou in July 2025, with nothing laid	Coastal landing complete, offshore laying scheduled for August 2026 and commissioning expected in the first quarter of 2027	Advanced

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
Via Africa submarine cable	Did not exist	A consortium memorandum signed by Canalink, GUILAB, International Mauritania Telecom, the Orange group, Sonatel and Silverlinks for a Europe-to-South-Africa system landing in Mauritania, Senegal, Guinea, Cote d'Ivoire and Nigeria; no cost, contract or in-service date held	Advanced

Data Exchange

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
SIGMAT (ECOWAS interconnected transit management system)	Operating on major corridors since 2019	A forward roadmap presented to the World Customs Organization and deployment agreed at three further border posts; the e-Hub and the regional guarantee system remain roadmap items	Advanced, m

Digital Identity and CRVS

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
AES biometric passport	Launched in January 2025, with no state-by-state issuance on record	Issuing in all three states, with Mali's supplied by China's Emptech in place of France's Idemia	Advanced

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
CIB-AES (AES biometric identity card)	Did not exist	Issuing in Burkina Faso since December 2025 and in Niger since March 2026, with mass enrolment under way and cross-border enrolment tested in Mali	Advanced
ENBIC (ECOWAS National Biometric Identity Card)	Operationalised by six member states, with no rollout held in the largest	Rolled out by Nigeria in November 2025 and deployed in the field in Guinea-Bissau under a cross-border traders' project	Advanced

Digital Payments and Fintech

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
Institutions connected to PI-SPI	45 at launch (2025-09-30)	80 at 2026-07-20, against 74 at the end of December 2025, with the central bank calling uptake gradual and the pace of new connections sharply slowed	Advanced
PI-SPI (UEMOA interoperable instant-payment platform)	In live testing from August 2025, ahead of a launch set for 30 September 2025	In service across the eight member states, free for person-to-person transfers, with banks and mobile money interconnected since May 2026	Advanced
Users connected to PI-SPI	Did not exist	30 million connected users and one million transactions worth 110 billion FCFA in under ten months	Advanced

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
BCEAO accession to the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System	Baseline not held	A six-month pilot with more than 80 commercial banks is planned before any decision, to test conformity with the union's external-financial-relations rules	Baseline not held
EPSS (ECOWAS Payment and Settlement System)	Baseline not held	Work is on where the platform's components will be hosted and on evaluating the central banks bidding to host them; no build, cost, timetable or legal instrument held	Baseline not held

Access to services

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
Open e-money accounts in the UEMOA	209,025,380 accounts (2023)	248,710,918 accounts (2024-12-31), of which 76,863,533 active, an activity rate of 30.9%	Advanced

PI-SPI carried the region's clearest movement. Launched across the eight member states on 2025-09-30, it reported 30 million connected users and one million transactions worth 110 billion FCFA at 2026-07-20. The BCEAO calls that uptake gradual: 80 institutions are connected against 74 at the end of December 2025 and 45 at launch, and states that the pace of new connections has slowed sharply. Beneath it sit 248,710,918 open e-money accounts at 2024-12-31, against 209,025,380 a year earlier.

Two cross-border tracks opened above the union rail, neither with an earlier position in the base. The BCEAO is participating in the ECOWAS Payment and Settlement System, where work is on hosting criteria and on the central banks bidding to host the platform's components, and is preparing accession to the continental system through a six-month pilot with more than 80 commercial banks.

Identity credentials advanced on both sides of the region's split. Nigeria [issued the ECOWAS biometric card from November 2025](#), and Niger [began mass enrolment for the confederal card](#) and Mali's passport passed from France's Idemia to China's Emptech after a data-transfer dispute.

Capacity added to the region was commercial. CSquared [added 2Africa West capacity to its own network](#) after three multi-country outages in 28 months at the Accra, Lagos and Abidjan landing concentration. A consortium of Canalink, GUILAB, International Mauritania Telecom, Orange, Sonatel and Silverlinks [signed a memorandum on 2026-05-13](#) for the Via Africa system, with no cost or in-service date on record; Mauritania's second cable [completed its coastal landing on 2026-05-04](#).

Coordination and collaboration

Digital Identity and CRVS

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
WURI (West Africa Unique Identification for Regional Integration and Inclusion)	Phase 2 running to a closing date of 30 July 2026, with no interoperability strategy validated	A cross-border interoperability and mutual-recognition strategy validated and a 2026 work plan adopted; the phase's stated closing date has passed with no completion, extension or successor record held	Advanced

Regional collaboration

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
Cotonou Declaration on digital transformation in West and Central Africa	Did not exist	Adopted by West and Central African states, committing to a single digital market by 2030; no implementation report, work plan or secretariat held in the nine months since	Advanced

Standards

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
Alliance ouest-africaine des noms de domaine (AOAN)	Did not exist	Announced as an initiative to coordinate country-code domain policy across the region; no charter, membership or founding act held	Advanced

Public debate and participation in policymaking

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
Regional Feminist Data Agenda 2026-2028	Did not exist	Ratified with three priorities for 2026-2028, each carrying a named owner, alongside eight thematic policy briefs and a cross-border encrypted data collective with rapid-response protocols; no text is published	Advanced

China activities

Body, Instrument or System	At 2025-08-01	At 2026-08-05	Movement
China-aid ECOWAS Headquarters Building	Baseline not held	Handed over to the Commission, the second international-organisation office complex China has built in Africa; China describes cooperation extending into the digital economy and names no digital programme, figure or instrument, and the Commission's own release names no digital component	Baseline not held

WURI, run by the World Bank with the ECOWAS Commission as co-secretariat, is the region's longest-running joint programme. An interoperability and mutual-recognition strategy for foundational identity was validated at Accra in August 2025 and again by the second supervisory committee, with a 2026 work plan. Phase 2 carries a closing date of 30 July 2026; that date has passed with no completion, extension or successor record held, and two of its four states have left ECOWAS.

West and Central African states adopted the Cotonou Declaration on 2025-11-18, committing to an integrated digital market by 2030; nine months on, no implementation report, work plan or secretariat is held. The period's one new structure was proposed by practitioners rather than institutions: an alliance of domain-name professionals, put to the SIPEN-UEMOA salon in July 2026.

Capacity and inclusion

Training and skills

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
EU-ECOWAS EPSG support for fact-checking platforms	Baseline not held	Two Nigerian organisations selected for in-kind technical support covering digital infrastructure , cybersecurity and verification systems, with training in AI, digital investigations and deepfake detection, and admission to a regional cross-border verification network; no amount, duration or start date is stated	Baseline not held

(narrative not yet written)

Finance

New investments

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
WARDIP (Western Africa Regional Digital Integration Program)	The first series alone: US\$293.00m across four states, ECOWAS, the African Union and Smart Africa	A second series approved on 2026-03-11 for Benin, Liberia and Sierra Leone, with Liberia's US\$50m share signed in June	Advanced
World Bank commitment to the WARDIP series	US\$293.00m, the first series (2023-11-07)	US\$430.00m across the two series, after US\$137.00m was approved on 2026-03-11	Advanced

Domestic budget appropriations and expenditure

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-08-01	AT 2026-08-05	MOVEMENT
ECOWAS Community Budget provision for digital programmes	No disaggregated digital or ICT line, and nil actual on the Youth Entrepreneurship in ICT line since 2023	The 2026-2028 MTEF carries no disaggregated digital or ICT line; Youth Entrepreneurship in ICT is nil from 2024 through the 2028 estimates, against UA 543,953 approved and UA 407,965 actual in 2022	No change

The regional layer's financing is a lender's. WARDIP's first series [committed US\\$293.00m](#); a [second series of US\\$137.00m was approved on 2026-03-11](#) for Benin, Liberia and Sierra Leone, taking the World Bank's commitment to US\$430.00m; Liberia [signed its US\\$50m share on 2026-06-08](#).

The bloc's own contribution is procedural: the Authority [directed the Commission to prioritise digital connectivity](#) alongside transport, energy and water in its project-preparation pipeline. No project list, envelope or first report is held, nor any budget line of ECOWAS, the UEMOA Commission or WATRA for their own digital work, so what the region spends on the layer above cannot be stated at either end of the period.

Where the record is thin

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT	LAST PROBED
ECOWAS Statistical Policy and Regional Statistical Programme 2023-2027	The policy and programme the July 2026 meeting was implementing, and the methodological guides it approved; probed 2026-08-05: neither located as a document; what was found is the World Bank statistics operation financing the work and a 2002-era secretariat programme	2026-08-05
Regional digital skills programme of a West African body	A programme document from ECOWAS, the UEMOA Commission or WATRA, as against the national skills components financed under WARDIP; probed 2026-08-05: no regional programme document located; what was found is a training-of-trainers activity in Liberia and a youth AI forum, both single events	2026-08-05

Six named objects carry no position at either end, and each was searched on 2026-08-05. Four searches returned published documents the base does not hold: the region's own digital sector strategy for 2024-2029, the community budget for 2026-2028, WATRA's technical reports, and a headquarters complex China financed for the ECOWAS Commission. These are gaps in this record rather than in the region's activity; acquisition lines have been raised, and none is cited above.

Two returned nothing. No regional digital skills programme of ECOWAS, the UEMOA Commission or WATRA was located, only single events; and neither the statistical policy nor the regional statistical programme the July 2026 meeting was implementing was located as a document, only the World Bank operation financing that work.

The searches expose a pattern that runs through the report: almost every instrument here is visible through a member state, a central bank, an operator, a lender or a press account of a meeting, and almost none through a publication of the body that made it. The communiqué of 2026-07-19 names five instruments adopted and reproduces none; the AES specifications have carried two credentials since 2024-11-22 without being published.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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